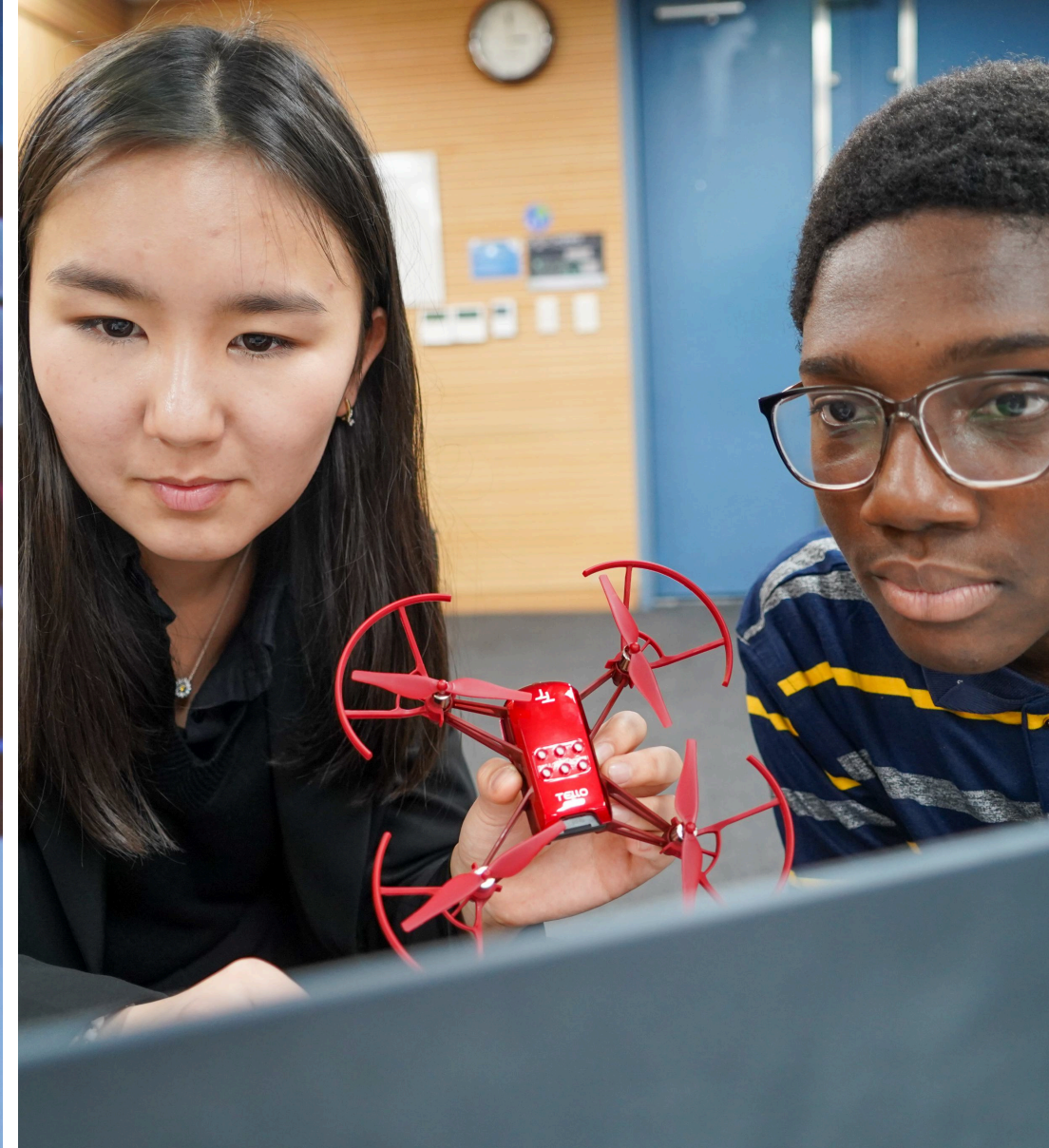




PBL CHALLENGE INSTRUCTIONS

2027-2028 Application

tg | THINK GLOBAL
SCHOOL

Hello, Prospective TGS Student!

The application process at THINK Global School (TGS) is designed to determine if the educational goals of both the prospective student/family and the school are compatible.

As part of your application to TGS, we want to provide your family with information to help you understand what project-based learning looks like at TGS. Please review this entire document, which gives you the background to conduct your own PBL research as part of our application process.

A Curriculum Designed for the 21st Century

The TGS Curriculum is non-traditional and based on some of the most innovative pedagogical practices in the world. Due to this, all students and families must be aware of how they'll be learning at TGS.

At TGS, learning isn't based on traditional one-hour classes. Instead, our students learn by participating in themed project modules that allow them to craft their own approach to driving questions and engage with the communities in which they are living.

These multi-disciplinary modules allow our students to explore relevant real-world issues by engaging with guest speakers and local community members.

Learning Driven by Values

TGS's Core Values guide learning inside and outside the classroom. These eight global values are the inspiration for all that we do:

Compassion: Consider others' needs and challenges with heartfelt curiosity and a genuine desire to offer support and kindness.

Sisu (Finnish): Extraordinary determination and resilience in the face of adversity.

Kaizen (Japanese): Continually improve – be self-aware, responsible, and disciplined.

Meraki (Greek): Put all of yourself – your soul, creativity and love – into your work.

Pixki "The Guardian" (Náhuatl): Modifying your actions to protect the environment while adopting a more sustainable lifestyle.

Qiú Zhi Yù (Mandarin): Thirst for knowledge – be open, be curious, and challenge assumptions.

Satya (Sanskrit): Live truth – in a way that is honest, steadfast, and uplifting to others.

Ubuntu (Zulu): Connect to a greater whole – in mutual support and community.



Section 1: What is Project-Based Learning?

Project-based learning (PBL) is an innovative and immersive educational approach that diverges from traditional classroom learning. Instead of learning passively, you'll be actively engaged in solving real-world problems through themed projects designed by our team of educators and, at times, by yourself.

Here's what you need to know about PBL at TGS:

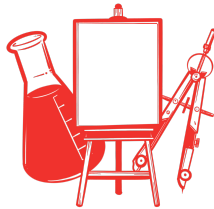
- 1. Real-World Focus:** TGS projects are centered around real-world topics and issues, making learning more relevant and engaging.
- 2. An Interdisciplinary Approach:** You'll integrate knowledge from different subjects to develop a well-rounded engagement with complex questions and challenges.
- 3. Student-Driven:** You'll have the autonomy to decide how to approach the project. This encourages creativity, critical thinking, and ownership of your learning.
- 4. Place-Based Education:** Your learning derives from the unique places you live throughout your time at TGS, with a deep respect for engaging with local knowledge and actively participating in local communities.
- 5. Reflection and Assessment:** Throughout all stages of the project, you will participate in reflections, feedback loops, and iterations. This helps in recognizing what you have learned and areas where you can improve.
- 6. Development of 21st-Century Skills:** PBL at THINK Global School is designed to prepare you for the future by developing 21st-century skills like problem-solving, communication, collaboration, and adaptability.
- 7. Values-Focused Learning:** TGS's core values guide our learning: Compassion, Sisu, Kaizen, Meraki, Pixki, Qiú Zhì Yù, Satya, and Ubuntu.

To sum it up: Project-based learning at TGS is an exciting, hands-on approach that makes learning more meaningful and prepares you for real-world challenges.

Does this sound like the way you like to learn? Keep reading to learn more about our project modules!



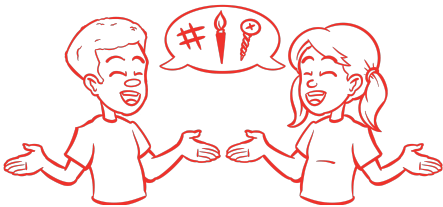
Real-World Focus



Interdisciplinary Approach



Student Driven



Place-Based Education



Reflection and Assessment



Development of 21st Century Skills



Values-Focused Learning

Section 2: What Does A PBL Module Look Like?

In project-based learning, educators adopt a dynamic role. Instead of acting as traditional instructors, they fluidly transition between being the primary source of information for a project and serving as facilitators and guides throughout its progression. They also ensure that the goals students set at the project's onset are met, learning targets are appropriately integrated, and any questions that arise are sufficiently answered.

Sound different from what you're used to? That's because PBL encourages students to take ownership of their learning. It's hands-on training for the real world, where you'll have to think critically and make important decisions for yourself and your team, regardless of the occupation.

One of the most important things you need to know about our modules is that they come in two forms: Teacher-led Modules and Personal Projects.

Teacher-led Modules (TLM)

Teacher-led Modules are the first type of PBL module at TGS. In a teacher-led module, you'll work in teams to gather facts, look for correlations, and evaluate possible solutions for projects designed by our educators and based around your host country. Besides developing the module, educators act as your academic advisor and help steer the course across the eight-week term.

During the first couple of weeks of each teacher-led module, you'll look at the driving question from all angles and determine how you'd like to approach it. Through this process, you'll decide on a final product that will be presented during the end-of-term showcase, where you and your teammates will demonstrate your learning by presenting before a live audience.



[Click here to watch Mehdiya present her project at the 2023 TGS Symposium](#)

Throughout the term, you and your teammates will meet with local experts, take meaningful excursions, and engage regularly with local communities. It won't take long before you realize just how much your global experiences deepen your projects' meaning and amplify their impact.

Following the showcase, you'll meet one more time with the educators overseeing the project to reflect on your work, discuss what was learned and if expectations were met, and see how the skills you gained can be built upon in subsequent projects.

Personal Projects

Personal Projects are the second type of PBL module at TGS. With the guidance of your academic mentor, you'll pursue projects that relate to personal interests, potential future paths, and service learning.

During these personal projects, you will formulate your own driving questions and select the learning targets you'd like to focus on. It's an opportunity to pursue your passions or tackle a subject you'd like to become more familiar with.

Personal projects can take many forms, including exploring new technologies and how they could impact the world, crafting an original piece of art, working with a local organization to tackle a community need, or creating a paper or presentation to document your new understanding of an element of local culture or history.



Your mentor will help plan and evaluate your projects, tracking them against the school's learning targets to ensure you get a well-rounded education covering all academic disciplines.

Similar to the teacher-led module, personal projects conclude with a reflection period between you and your project advisor. [Use this link](#) to view past projects TGS students have submitted.

Section 3: The Student Experience

Now that you have an understanding of what project-based learning is, we'll dive a bit deeper into the components of each. Every module/project at TGS includes the following: a driving question, a process portfolio, learning targets, a project proposal, and the final product. Here's a more detailed look at each.

The Driving Question

In project-based learning, a driving question is the central question of a module or personal project that guides students throughout the PBL process. It's a clear and engaging question that focuses a student's work toward solving a real-world problem or answering a complex issue.

Driving questions are provocative, open-ended, centered around a specific discipline, challenging, and aligned with curricular standards and frameworks. Most importantly, they help students stay on track by giving a clear purpose to the project.

Real Driving Question from Malaysia

How is pluralism experienced, negotiated, or challenged in everyday life in Sabah?

The Process Portfolio

A process portfolio is a journal encompassing a student's work, reflections, and documentation throughout a project. It acts as a dynamic record of their growth, skill development, and learning journey.

The portfolio serves several vital purposes in PBL, including fostering reflection and metacognition, aiding in assessment and evaluation, ensuring documentation and accountability, and facilitating communication and presentation of the student's work.

In closing: the process portfolio is a multifaceted tool that encourages students to take ownership of and engage deeply with their learning process.



Driving Question



Process Portfolio



Learning Targets



Project Proposal



Final Product

Learning Targets

Learning targets are concrete goals, written in student-friendly language, that succinctly describe what students will learn and be able to do by the end of a project. They are an essential component in planning and implementing modules or personal projects.

There are ten different categories of learning targets at THINK Global School, each containing subcategories representing a diverse spectrum of learning objectives.

In multidisciplinary environments like TGS, projects typically integrate learning targets from multiple categories. These targets provide focus, clarity, and serve as a basis for assessment. They also encourage student reflection, self-assessment, and boost engagement by presenting clear and attainable goals.

Our Learning Targets

Intercultural Communication	Creative & Expressive Arts	Mathematical Models, Patterns & Problem-Solving
Language is the passport to understanding the world. Students will explore how storytelling, rhetoric, and communication transcend cultures, shaping our interactions across borders.	Art is an expression that transcends time, culture, and geography. It invites us to analyze, question, and create meaning through different forms of expression. How can we effectively interpret and refine artistic works to communicate ideas and emotions?	Mathematics is the language of patterns, predictions, and problem-solving. It helps us make sense of the world, from analyzing data trends to designing structures and modeling real-life phenomena.
THINKing, Exploration & Discovery	Innovation & Technology	People, Places & Perspectives
Research is the foundation of knowledge discovery, allowing us to ask questions, analyze information, and generate original insights. By applying different research techniques, we can explore complex issues and contribute to the advancement of understanding in various fields.	Innovation bridges scientific discovery with practical solutions. Through applied science, technology, and engineering, students investigate how things work, solve real-world problems, and imagine future possibilities—ethically, sustainably, and creatively.	To understand the world, we must explore the people, cultures, systems, and ideas that shape it. Through anthropology, sociology, geography, history, and philosophy, students critically examine how human societies evolve, interact, and influence the present and future.
Wholebeing	Interdependence and Regeneration	World Languages
Wholebeing is about cultivating a full, balanced life—physically, emotionally, socially, and purposefully. It empowers students to make intentional choices for their well-being, engage meaningfully in their communities, and take ownership of their futures with confidence and compassion.	Interdependence and Regeneration is about understanding the systems that sustain life—both natural and human-made—and taking responsibility for how we impact them.	Mastering an additional language, whether spoken, technical, or symbolic, allows us to connect with others, navigate global interactions, and expand our cognitive abilities. It is the key to understanding different cultures, perspectives, and ways of thinking.
Enterprise Skills		
Entrepreneurship is about recognizing opportunities, developing innovative solutions, and creating value in an ever-evolving world. By applying business strategies, ethical considerations, and creative problem-solving, students can turn ideas into impactful ventures.		

The Project Proposal

The project proposal serves as a roadmap, outlining the elements needed, including a title, the driving question, relevant background information or context, and specific objectives and learning targets.

Additionally, the proposal includes the methodology and research sources to be used and a timeline with milestones and deadlines. It also lists the materials and resources needed and sets out assessment criteria for evaluating the project's success.

Furthermore, the proposal addresses anticipated challenges along with strategies to overcome them, describes the expected end product, and outlines plans for reflection on learning progress.

A critical step is presenting this proposal to a student's academic advisor. This presentation allows students to explain the project's components and gain valuable feedback and guidance, ensuring a well-thought-out and structured approach to achieving their goals.

The Final Product

In project-based learning, the final product is the tangible outcome that students create, representing the culmination of their learning process. The form of the final product can vary widely depending on the proposal and the nature of the project. It can range from research papers, presentations, and websites to more creative outputs such as songs, poems, short stories, or physical items like clothing, shoes, or models.

At THINK Global School, showcasing these final products is integral to the learning process. Students present their work at the end of every term, allowing them to communicate their understanding, share their learning journey, and receive feedback. This practice also provides an opportunity for assessment and reflection on students' skills and knowledge gained throughout the project.



Bernice shares her project during the India 2025 Showcase.

Section 4: Introducing the PBL Challenge

Congrats on making it this far! Now let's bring on the challenge!

The PBL Challenge aims to assess prospective students' comprehensive understanding of project-based learning in preparation for their time at THINK Global School. We do not expect perfection, but we expect to see critical thinking, creativity, comprehension, research methods, mastery of digital tools, time management, and planning skills to complete the challenge we have in place. We want you to commit time and energy to this project, but we ask that you spend no more than 10 hours developing this project.

Ready to take the challenge? Here we go. 📌

The PBL Challenge: Creating an Innovation for a Better Future

1. Design a project around the following driving question:

How can I identify a specific local challenge in my home community and create an innovation inspired by one of TGS's core values to address this issue?

2. Create a final product in the form of a PDF

This is your chance to get creative and show us your best and brightest ideas! You do not need to go out and implement the innovation you are proposing, but you need to tell us about why your idea is a valid one to solve the local challenge you have identified.

Your submission:

- Must clearly state what the local challenge is and the innovation you hope to create to address it.
- Must be between 750-1000 words.
- Can include illustrations, videos, diagrams, photos, or any other items you feel will help explain your final product. This must be in addition to the writing.
- Must define which of the TGS core values inspired the project and why.
- Must share what skills you used/learned while completing the project.
- Must contain a reflection on how what you learned in this local experience could be applied in a global context or in a different global situation.

Once Complete:

Submit your finished PDF via the application portal in OpenApply.

Good Luck!